

Divided Tata house does not inspire confidence

A BITTER power struggle is raging within the Tata Group. Barely a month after N Chandrasekaran, Tata Sons chairman, announced his decision to not seek an extension, the board of the holding company has approved another five year term for him. This dramatic turn of events came even as Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, opposed the decision. The Tata Sons board has, in other words, gone against its largest shareholder — Tata Trusts hold about 66 per cent stake in the holding company. These developments, rather than resolving differences, bringing a finality to the leadership question and placing the group on stronger footing, could well precipitate an institutional crisis. A protracted legal battle may ensue. This would be neither in the best interests of the group, its shareholders nor the larger economy.

Internal conflicts in the group have been simmering for some time. Noel Tata and Chandrasekaran have reportedly had strong differences of opinion on several issues. The Tata trustees have themselves been at loggerheads. Parallels can be drawn of similar power struggles. For instance, when Ratan Tata took over as chairman he had eased out the powerful old satraps. The ouster of Cyrus Mistry as chairman of Tata Sons was equally bitter. But, there is another element to the recent boardroom machinations that will have far-reaching ramifications for the group. The board has also decided to pursue a public listing following RBI's decision to reject Tata Sons' application to surrender its registration as a core investment company. This decision too was opposed by Noel Tata, who has stated his intention to keep the company private. These matters are now likely to move to the annual general meeting where both the decisions will be put to the test.

A prolonged period of ambiguity over leadership and the issue of public listing is undesirable and will raise questions over the functioning of the group. The questions that have arisen over leadership and succession, over the group's governance structure, the limits of control, and the relationship between the trusts, the holding company and the operating entities, need to be clearly answered and resolved. The lines of power and accountability need to be clearly delineated and greater transparency in dealings and operations must be pursued. The group, which is engaged across a large spectrum of activities including areas of national importance, cannot afford a period of uncertainty and instability. The Tatas must put their house in order.

Punjab's drug scourge needs policy, not slogans

PUNJAB'S DRUG menace has outlived a dozen crack-downs and three governments. It returns now, as it has before successive elections, to the centre of the state's politics. On Friday, the BJP, which says it will contest all 117 seats on its own, flagged off the first of four "Nasha Mukh Punjab" yatras under the slogan, "Bhaipja Da Naara, Nasha Mukh Saara". The party's president Nitin Nabin launched the campaign, which will cover nearly 4,000 km before culminating in Jalandhar on September 30, where Union Home Minister Amit Shah is expected to address a rally. The Congress has responded in kind. Its Punjab in-charge, Sachin Pilot, led a protest in Chandigarh over the death of labourer Gulzar Singh, who had questioned state Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema about the availability of drugs and later died by suicide. Last month, Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) leaders also made drugs the centrepiece of their campaign at the Rakhar Puniya rally, promising a white paper on the scourge.

Geography has long been cited as one reason for the problem. The state lies at the edge of the Golden Crescent and shares a roughly 550-km border with Pakistan. But the trade has outgrown the border. Drones ferry consignments, other states have become relay points, and pharmaceutical drugs — cheaper, more accessible and harder to trace — have become an important part of the trade. The AAP government's "Yudh Nashayan Viruddh", launched in March 2025, has produced arrests and seizure figures in abundance. But there's been no visible slowdown in the contraband flow. Families are destroyed, while many young Punjabis leave the state in search of a future abroad. The role of families in prevention and recovery is important, but the state cannot abdicate its responsibility. It must dismantle the networks controlling the trade, prosecute those who finance and supply it, and ensure treatment and rehabilitation for those caught in addition.

Punjab has heard several promises of a drug-free state. It does not need another slogan or another round of statistics. A serious response must go beyond arrests and seizures to examine the money trails, supply routes and institutional failures that allow the trade to survive. The government must also provide accessible treatment, sustained rehabilitation and opportunities for young people to rebuild their lives. As the 2027 election approaches, the persistence of the drug trade will put the AAP government's record under scrutiny. But the larger test is for Punjab's political class: It needs to turn a recurring election promise into sustained policy.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

India will de-risk, not decouple, from US and China

THE UNITED States has taken one more step in its ongoing campaign to punish India for asserting her national interest in the pursuit of economic development. The United States Congress has voted overwhelmingly in favour of the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act 2026. This authorises the US President to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on goods from the five largest purchasers of Russian oil and gas, namely, China, India, Slovakia, Hungary and Azerbaijan. America's European allies have been exempted on the pretext that they are trying to reduce their consumption of Russian energy. President Donald Trump now has the power to act. He will probably use this weapon to strike a range of deals with the five countries before, in fact, utilising his power in full.

President Trump began taking economic actions against India in 2017 when he ended the Generalised System of Preferences (GSP) and began increasing tariffs on a range of commodities and products. That process went through its ups and downs but there has been no retreat. Actions taken against India have remained in place. Some threatened actions have not yet been taken but not called off either. Pressure on India to stop oil imports from Venezuela was ended after the US staged a coup and changed the regime in that country. Now India is being asked to buy Venezuelan oil.

While some of Trump's geopolitical initiatives have unsettled New Delhi, with his hosting of the Pakistani Field Marshal for lunch at the White House constituting the nadir, it is the geoeconomic sanctions

that will really have a long-term impact on the relationship.

In this context, some analysts have suggested a "de-Americanisation" of Indian foreign policy. To an extent this has already happened. India's impressive hosting of the BRICS Summit, with both China's Xi Jinping and Russia's Vladimir Putin in attendance, was certainly a message to Western critics of the group. However, there are objective limits to "de-Americanisation" set by economic and business links.

The fact is that the US remains an important market for Indian exports of goods and services. The people-to-people and business-to-business connection is strong and enduring, though it is entirely possible for state-to-state relations to deteriorate despite robust people and business links. The US, in this regard, is in a league of its own, with large sections of the Indian power elite emigrating to the US.

The defence relationship, too, has become important, but India has options. The growing defence partnership with countries like France, Japan, Britain, Sweden and other European countries, as well as India's atmanirbharata in defence policy, can help reduce India's dependence not just on the US but also Russia and Israel. What is entirely possible is the ending of any "strategic" dependence on the US that may have been thought of after the signing of the US-India Civil Nuclear Agreement. That dependence was built on a new sense of trust that we owe to the leadership of President George Bush. With President Trump, trust is gone.



SANJAYA BARU

Consider, as an aside, the relationship between the US and China. It is a relationship bereft of trust but economic links keep it going, even after it has become more adversarial. In 2017, Trump entered office declaring that he would "decouple" the US economy from China. On Labour Day in September 2020, Trump declared from the White House: "So when you mention the word 'decouple', it's an interesting word. So we lose billions of dollars, and if we didn't do business with them, we wouldn't lose billions of dollars. It's called 'decoupling'. So you'll start thinking about it. You'll start thinking."

The idea was quickly picked up by President Joe Biden and a bipartisan consensus seemed to be building in favour of "decoupling". The Washington DC think-tank and policy circuit went into high gear theorising and estimating the costs of "decoupling", till Biden's own administration officials realised that decoupling was a fantasy. "The US will assert ourselves when our vital interests are at stake. But we do not seek to 'decouple' our economy from China's," cautioned Janet Yellen, then US treasury secretary, adding, "A full separation of our economies would be disastrous for both countries. It would be destabilising for the rest of the world."

Yellen's caution was followed up by a clearer statement by the US national security advisor, Jake Sullivan. In a lecture delivered a week later, on April 27, 2023, at the influential Washington DC think tank, Brookings Institution, Sullivan ended a long and substantial address on US economic strategy aimed at reviving and revitalising

● **WORDLY WISE**
The execution of the laws is more important than the making of them. — *Thomas Jefferson*

In the foreseeable future, India will have to deal with the twin challenge of managing one major power in decline and another major power on the rise. Few countries have been in this situation before

India's BRICS diplomacy is more than one summit's result



TARIQ MANSOOR

A RECENT column, "Dear Editor, I Disagree: Dialogue at BRICS is a means, not an end" (IE, September 16), argued for testing the usefulness of multilateral forums such as BRICS on the tangible outcomes they produce and not by the agency they provide for dialogue and diplomacy. The argument falls short, especially in the context of developments surrounding the West Asia war at BRICS 2026.

Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) used the occasion for their first high-level bilateral meeting since the war began. Since the initiation of a dialogue cannot be expected to produce immediate settlements, its value cannot be judged by the ends it may ultimately achieve. The significance of the declaration on West Asia lies not only in what it says, but in the fact that there was a declaration at all. In such conflict, the floor provided by BRICS 2026 represents that a means can be an outcome.

A section of the analysts have compared the BRICS New Delhi Declaration 2026 with the Rio BRICS Declaration 2025. The Rio declaration condemned the military strikes against Iran as a violation of international law and the UN Charter. By the plain measure of textual strength, the Delhi Declaration might seem to be a retreat. Yet, read carefully, the weaker sentence is the more significant achievement, and the reason lies in what changed between the two summits.

In June 2025, Iran was a member of BRICS that had been attacked. Every other member could condemn the attack without contradicting its own position. By February 2026, when the US and Israel struck again, Iran had responded by striking targets across the Gulf, including the territory of its fellow members. The UAE has absorbed more Iranian projectiles than any other Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) state, and subsequently suspended trade and financial dealings with Tehran. The condemnation formula available in Rio was not available in New Delhi, not because the chair lacked resolve but because the members had become belligerents against one another.

The measure of the Delhi outcome cannot, therefore, be Rio. In May 2026, BRICS

foreign ministers met in New Delhi and produced nothing at all. In March, the External Affairs Ministry had publicly conceded the difficulty, noting that members were directly involved in the conflict and that India, as chair, was working the Sherpa channel to narrow differences. Four months after the ministerial failure, 11 members adopted a declaration by consensus. Where they agreed, the language stayed precise, reiterating the importance of the Palestinian question and the two-state solution. Where they disagreed, the language built a floor instead of delivering a verdict.

The diplomatic capital visible at BRICS did not arise in 2026. It has been accumulated over a decade in which the Modi government has altered both the political grammar and structure of India's engagement with the Gulf — a shift from traditional oil and trade to more strategic spheres of defence, technology, and security. Most consequentially, the Modi years have demonstrated that India's relationships in West Asia need not be organised as mutually exclusive choices. BRICS 2026 allowed India to position itself as a state capable of understanding the security anxieties of the Arab Gulf without treating Iran's isolation as an objective, and capable of engaging Iran without appearing indifferent to Gulf security. Relationships cultivated across binaries can themselves become diplomatic assets. Strategic autonomy does more than create manoeuvring room for India; it can create diplomatic room between others.

Despite the diplomatic dividends for India at the summit, there are limits to what this means. A summit declaration does not make India a direct mediator in West Asia. Formal mediation requires acceptance by the parties, a mandate and a negotiating agenda. What Delhi can instead offer is more specific and valuable — trusted channels especially when they are scarce, political access across opposing capitals, and the ability to enlarge the space for accommodation without demanding geopolitical allegiance.

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What we need to learn, before AI learns too much



AMMEL SHARON

EARLIER THIS year, hundreds of AI agents being tested by OpenAI found a way to form what they called a "collective", cheated on their assigned tasks and broke into the systems of HuggingFace, a collaborative AI platform. Some sacrificed their own runs to tell the collective how they had been detected. None alerted a human being. The American journalist Josh Tyrangiel observed that if people had done what the agents did, it would constitute a felony. The incident puts the familiar question of whether AI might one day threaten humanity in a different light. The problem is no longer what AI might eventually do, but what we already cannot adequately understand or control.

This is not the first time human knowledge has raised the possibility of human extinction. The 20th century was made human self-destruction imaginable on an unprecedented scale. Psychoanalysis gave us the language of a death drive: The possibility that our capacity to create might coexist with an impulse towards destruction. Benjamin Labatut's *When We Cease to Understand the World* returns to this history through the lives of mathematicians, chemists and physicists, dismantling the account of science as a succession of heroic discoveries. German chemist Fritz Haber synthesised ammonia from nitrogen gas and hydrogen gases, a breakthrough that averted global famine. But he also oversaw the first use of poison gas at Ypres in 1915.

Labatut also raises the question of responsibility for what knowledge makes possible. In the novel, mathematician Alexander Grothendieck withdraws from the field in horror, declaring that the atoms that destroyed Hiroshima and Nagasaki were split not by generals but by physicists. Scientific inquiry in the novel is beautiful, productive and terrifying, while its protagonists display obsession, uncertainty and fear as much as reason. Literature makes these contradictions visible, restoring the personalities, associations and irrationality that disappear when discovery is presented as the orderly and inevitable progress of reason. Labatut's later novel, *The MANIAC*, moves from John von Neumann to artificial intelligence, carrying the same questions of knowledge, responsibility and control into the age of computing.

At NLS Bengaluru, our first-year students recently completed a course in reading, writing and critical thinking around the theme "Things Fall Apart". Across nine works we asked what happens when certainties collapse. Wisdom, they read in Plato, begins with recognising what one does not know, and acting accordingly. They asked how we might act with foreknowledge of death, whether scientific inquiry can be extricated from social concerns, and whether autonomy can itself become destructive. The pleasure of the classroom lay in watching these questions change as students debated them and arrived at claims of their own. This is a capacity we need in the age of AI. While machines can produce answers at extraordinary speed, the humanities and social sciences give us the means to examine their assumptions and determine which questions still need to be asked.

The problem is no longer what AI might eventually do, but what we already cannot adequately understand or control

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40 YEARS AGO

September 21, 1986



Global trade talks

MINISTERS FROM more than 70 nations meeting at Punta Del Este have agreed to launch a new round of global trade negotiations that will cover goods and services in separate parts, according to a declaration proposed to be adopted by them. To carry out multilateral trade negotiations, the draft declaration announced the establishment of a trade negotiations committee, which shall hold its first meeting "not later than" October 31. The document drew a distinction between negotiations on trade in goods — to be conducted by the contracting parties to the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade — and those on trade in services — to be conducted by "ministers".

Jyoti Basu warns PM

WEST Bengal Chief Minister, Jyoti Basu, said that a proper lesson should be learnt from the Punjab situation and the Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, should be careful in his statements on the Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF) movement. Basu said the PM's statement that the GNLF movement was not anti-national but related to question of citizenship had been greeted in Darjeeling by the bursting of crackers and torch processions by GNLF supporters.

UK to deport JKLF leader

BRITAIN ANNOUNCED it is deporting Amanullah Khan, a Kashmir separatist

(JKLF) leader living in Britain. The Home Secretary, Douglas Hurd, ruled that his expulsion was "conducive to the public good" but did not elaborate. Khan, a 50-year-old Pakistani living in Luton, 55 km north of London, was arrested a year ago with five other Kashmiris in a police crackdown on Kashmiri militants living in Britain.

Two die after drinking 'sura'

TWO MEN died in the Capital because they consumed too much of a "tonic". A third fell seriously ill and is in hospital. The two, both autorickshaw drivers, are Narender Kumar (26) and Ramesh Kumar (25), neighbours in Nai Basti at Kishanganj.